Week 10 / Thursday

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Question

You are asked to give a presentation. What do you need to prepare?

Tufte Has Feelings

Imagine a widely used and expensive prescription drug that claimed to make us beautiful but didn't. Instead the drug had frequent, serious side effects: making us stupid, degrading the quality and credibility of our communication, turning us into bores, wasting our colleagues' time. These side effects, and the resulting unsatisfactory cost/benefit ratio, would rightly lead to a worldwide product recall.
– Tufte, The Cognitive Style of Powerpoint, 24

On Bullet Points

How is it that each elaborate architecture of thought always fits exactly on one slide? The rigid slide- by-slide hierarchies, indifferent to content, slice and dice the evidence into arbitrary compartments, producing an anti-narrative with choppy continuity. Medieval in its preoccupation with hierarchical distinctions, the PowerPoint format signals every bullet's status in 4 or 5 different simultaneous ways: by the order in sequence, extent of indent, size of bullet, style of bullet, and size of type associated with various bullets.
– Tufte, The Cognitive Style of Powerpoint, 10

Low-Resolution Display, Low-Resolution Thinking

PP slides projected up on the wall are very low resolution—compared to paper, 35mm slides, and the immensely greater capacities of the human eye-brain system. Impoverished space leads to over-generalizations, imprecise statements, slogans, lightweight evidence, abrupt and thinly-argued claims.

– Tufte, The Cognitive Style of Powerpoint, 4

The Dictatorial Style of PowerPoint

The pushy PP style imposes itself on the audience and, at times, seeks to set up a dominance relationship between speaker and audience. The speaker, after all, is making power points with bullets to followers. Such aggressive, stereotyped, over-managed presentations–the Great Leader up on the pedestal–are characteristic of hegemonic systems. . . . A better metaphor for presentations is good teaching.
– Tufte, The Cognitive Style of Powerpoint, 13

Templates

The PP cognitive style is propagated by the templates, textbooks, style- sheets, and complete pitches available for purchase. Some corporations and government agencies require employees to use designated PPPhluft and presentation logo-wear. With their strict generic formats, these designer stylesheets serve only to enforce the limitations of PowerPoint, compromising the presenter, the content, and, ultimately, the audience.

– Tufte, The Cognitive Style of Powerpoint, 19

The Infamous Tufte Meme

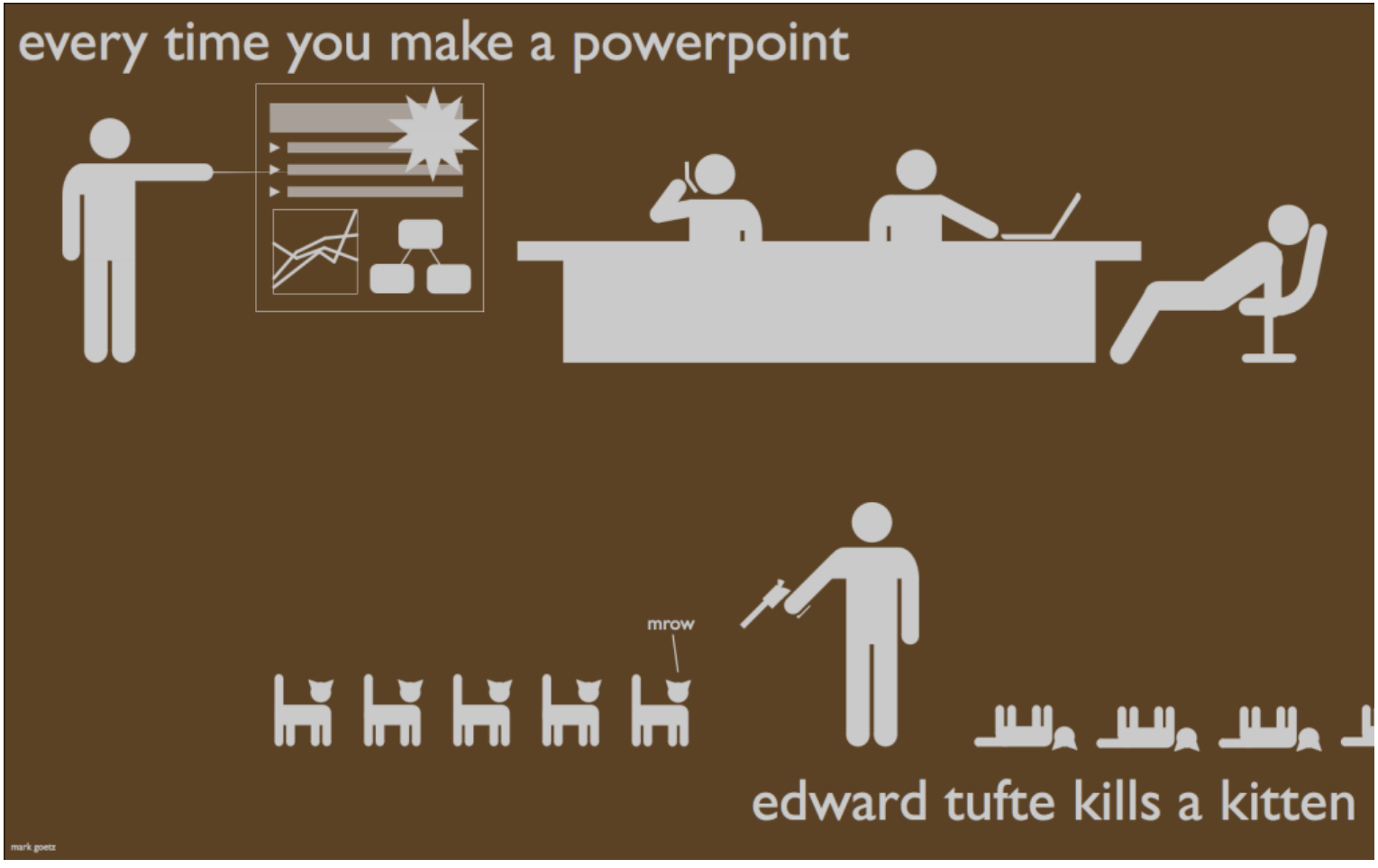


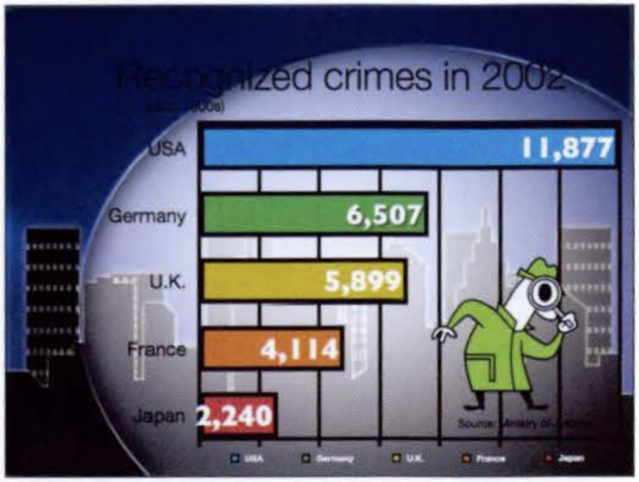
Figure: I'm sorry.

Slide Design: Foreground What's Important

Audiences are bored by bullet-points and learn nothing. Craft a narrative with your slides that supports your presentation. Prioritize content over everything, especially templates. A slide might look nice. But did anyone learn anything?

Slide Design: Signal to Noise Ratio

BEFORE



AFTER

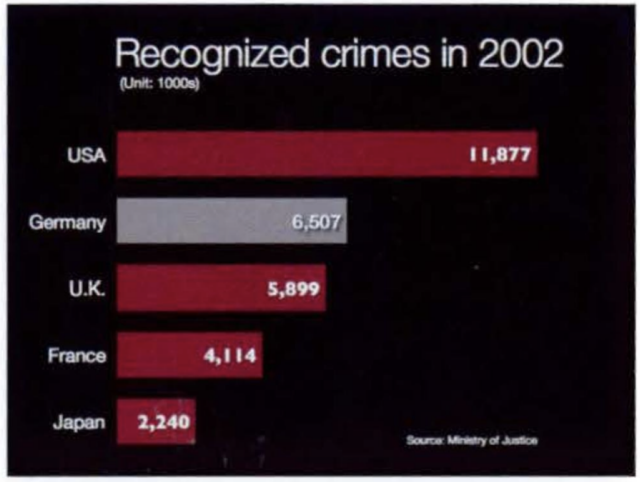


Figure: Information over everything. (Especially aesthetics.)

Slide Design: The Picture Superiority Effect



Figure: Images stick, text (usually) doesn't. Photo by Marija Zaric on Unsplash.

Slide Design: Prioritize White Space



Figure: It's hard to take anything away from this.